

ART AND CULTURE



LANGUAGE AND LITERATURE

- SANGAM LITERATURE
- MALAYALAM LITERATURE

MODULE – 6



TAMIL (SANGAM) LITERATURE

- 1 Early classical Tamil literature is known as Sangam literature meaning 'fraternity', indicating mainly two schools of poets, **aham** (love poems), and **puram** (public poetry and heroic).



Agastyar, Chairman of first Tamil Sangams.

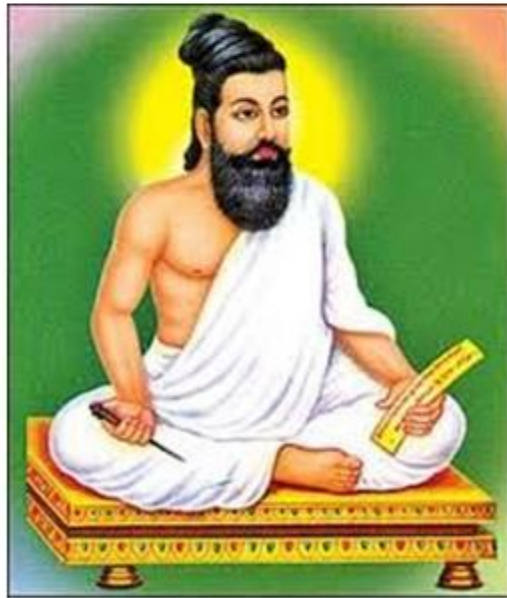
- 2 This collection contains 2381 poems in Tamil composed by 473 poets, some 102 of whom remain anonymous.
- 3 Most of the available Sangam literature is from the **Third Sangam**.
- 4 The poets included men and women from different classes of society.
- 5 The literary tradition was so popular that the period between 300 BC and 300 AD, during which most of these were composed and compiled, is often called **Sangam period**.

TAMIL (SANGAM) LITERATURE

- 6 Sangam literature fell out of popular memory soon thereafter, until they were rediscovered in the 19th century by scholars such as Arumuga Navalar, C. W. Thamothersampillai and U. V. Swaminatha Iyer.



U. V. SWAMINATHA IYER



THIRUVALLUVAR

- 7 Sangam literature deals with emotional and material topics such as love, war, governance, trade and bereavement.
- 8 Some of the greatest Tamil scholars, like Thiruvalluvar wrote not only on ethics, but also on the various issues of life like virtue, wealth and love.
- 9 Others like poet Mamulanar explored historical incidents that happened in India during the Sangam period.

TAMIL (SANGAM) LITERATURE

MAJOR SCHOOLS OF
SANGAM LITERATURE

AGAM

Comprises of personal or human aspects, such as love and intimate relationships.



PURAM

Discusses all other aspects of human experience such as heroism, courage, ethics, philanthropy, social life, and customs.



10 There are two major schools of Sangam literature:

- **aham**/agam which is the 'inner field' and concentrates on the abstract discussion of human aspects like love, sexual relations, etc.
- The second school is the '**puram**' or the 'outer field' which discusses the human experiences like social life, ethics, valour, customs, etc

11 Equally unique to Akam poetry, is the recognition that **human emotions are intimately influenced by their physical setting or geographical landscape.**

TAMIL (SANGAM) LITERATURE

- 12** The Tamil country was divided into **five different regions or tinai**, and the images associated with each region used to portray a distinct mood or experience.



KURINJI



PALAI



NEYTAL



MULLAI



MARUTHAM

- 13** Sangam literature illustrates this thematic classification scheme in the **Tolkāppiyam**.
- 14** These landscapes called **tinai** are as follows
- **Kurinji**- mountainous regions;
 - **Mullai**- forests;
 - **Marutam**- agricultural land;
 - **Neytal**- coastal regions;
 - **Palai**- deserts.
- 15** The two non-geographical modes, **kaikkilai** and **peruntinai**, were seen as dealing with emotions that were **unnatural**, and therefore were **not** associated with any specific landscape.
- 16** Kaikkilai dealt with unreciprocated or **one-sided love**, while peruntinai dealt with **improper love** or **love against the rules of custom**.

TAMIL (SANGAM) LITERATURE

17

Each *tiṇai* was closely associated with a particular landscape, and imagery associated with that landscape —its flowers, trees, wildlife, people, climate and geography—was woven into the poem in such a way as to convey a mood, associated with one aspect of a romantic relationship.

LANDSCAPE	KURINJI	MULLAI	MARUTHAM	NEYTAL	PALAI
MOOD EXPRESSED	Union of Lovers	Waiting for the other	Quarelling; Sulking of lover.	Pining ie suffer from longing	Separation of lovers
FLOWER	Kurinji (Strobilanthes)	Mullai	Marutham	Water Lily	Paalai



TAMIL (SANGAM) LITERATURE

- 18** This literature bears the name 'Sangam' because the kingdom of Pandya organised assemblies where poets, bards and writers would flock from various parts of South India.



- 19** These assemblies were called 'Sangams' and the literature produced in the duration of these assemblies was called Sangam literature.
- 20** According to the compilers of the Sangam works such as Nakkeerar, the Tamil Sangams were academies, where Tamil poets and authors are said to have gathered periodically to publish their works.
- 21** The legends claim that the Pandyan dynasty of the cities of "South Madurai", Kapatapuram and Madurai, patronized the three Sangams.

TAMIL (SANGAM) LITERATURE

There were three Sangams organized over a period of 600-700 years. However, the conclusive historical account of the first two Sangams are mostly not available.

SANGAM	KINGDOM	PLACE OF ORGANISATION	CHAIRMAN	BOOKS
FIRST	Pandya	Madurai	Agastya	No books survived
SECOND	Pandya	Kapatapuram	Initially, it was Agastya and then his disciple Tolkappiyar took over	Around 2,000 poems were collected and compiled into Tolkappiyam.
THIRD	Pandya	Madurai	Nakkirar	Most of the existing corpus of Sangam literature was written.

TAMIL (SANGAM) LITERATURE

SANGAM LITERATURE

Patineṇmēlkaṇakku

"Eighteen Greater Texts"

- These are narrative texts.
- Comprise of 8 anthologies and 10 Idylls which are known as ettuthogai and pathupaattu.

Patineṇkīlkaṇakku

"Eighteen Lesser Texts"

- These are didactic texts.

22

- The available Sangam literature was categorized and compiled in the 10th century into two categories based roughly on chronology.
- The categories are the **patineṇmēlkaṇakku** ("the eighteen greater text series") comprising the ettuthogai ("eight anthologies") and the pattuppāṭṭu ("ten idylls") and the **patineṇkīlkaṇakku** ("the eighteen lesser text series").

TAMIL (SANGAM) LITERATURE

23 The very famous and revered Tamil saint **Thiruvallurar** had contributed the '**Kural**' to the Sangam literature.

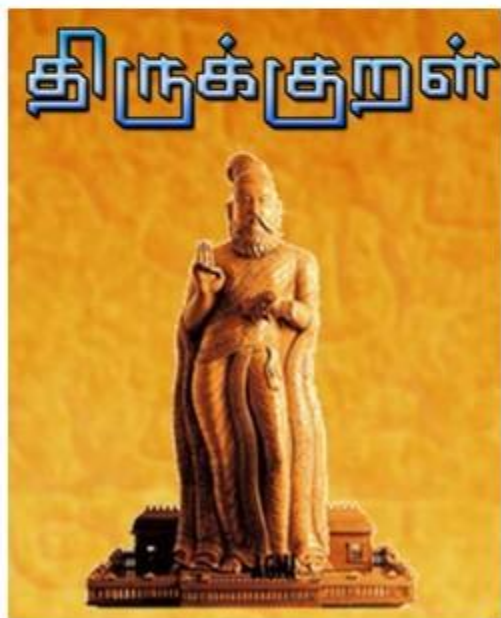


24 It has been now translated in several languages and is divided into three parts which discuss the **ethics, polity-governance and love.**



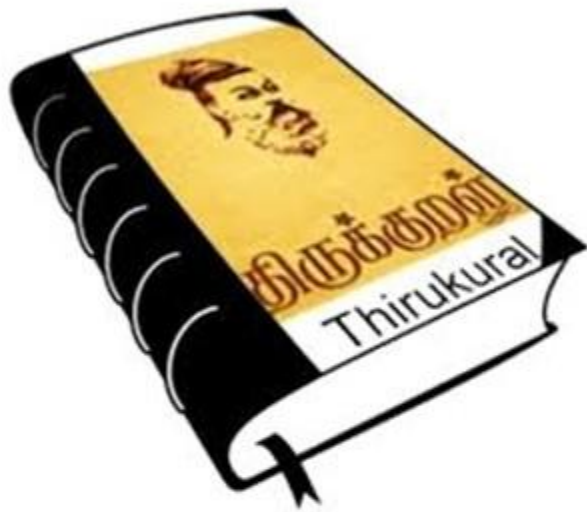
TAMIL (SANGAM) LITERATURE

- 25** The Tirukkural is a classic Tamil text consisting of **1,330 couplets** or Kurals, dealing with the everyday virtues of an individual.



- 26** It is one of the two oldest works now extant in Tamil literature in their entirety, the other being the Tolkappiyam.
- 27** Considered one of the greatest works ever written on ethics and morality, chiefly secular ethics, it is known for its universality and non-denominational nature.
- 28** It was authored by Valluvar, also known in full as Thiruvalluvar.
- 29** The **text has been dated variously** from 300 BCE to 5th century CE but the traditional accounts describe it as the last work of the **third Sangam**.

TAMIL (SANGAM) LITERATURE



30 Traditionally praised as "the Universal Veda" and "the Universal Code of Conduct", the Kural emphasizes on the vital principles of non-violence, moral vegetarianism or veganism, human brotherhood, absence of desires, path of righteousness and truth.

31 The Kural is structured into 133 chapters, each containing 10 couplets (or kural), for a total of 1,330 couplets.

32 The 133 chapters are grouped into three parts, or "books":

- **Aram**- Book of Virtue(Dharma)
- **Porul**- Book of Polity(Artha)
- **Inbam**- Book of Love(Kama)

TAMIL (SANGAM) LITERATURE



AVVAIYAR

- 33** Another famous female saint who contributed to Sangam literature is **Avvaiyar**.

- 34** Apart from the Sangam literature, there are many well-known texts written in Tamil.

- 35** The **Tolkappiyam** was written to elaborate on the **nuances of Tamil grammar and poetry**.

- 36** Like the twin Sanskrit epics, Ramayana and Mahabharata, **Tamil has five great epics**. They are- **Cilappatikāram, Manimekalai, Cīvaka Cintāmaṇi, Valayapathi and Kuṇṭalakēsi**.

TAMIL (SANGAM) LITERATURE

NAME OF THE BOOK	AUTHOR
Cilappatikāram	Ilango Adigal
Manimekalai	Sīthalai Sāttanār
Cīvaka Cintāmaṇi	Tirutakkatevar
Valayapathi	Unknown Jain ascetic
Kundalakēci	Nathakuthanar

37 These texts focus on the Tamil society and the **economic and political changes** it was experiencing.

38 The final turn came during the early medieval period when the **Vaishnava Bhakti sentiments** began to colour Tamil literature.

39 Texts composed between seventh to twelfth centuries were highly devotional in nature.

TAMIL (SANGAM) LITERATURE



40 Out of this five texts, the two most important ones are **Silappadikaram** and **Manimekalai**.

41 The epic trio of **Cilappatikāram**, **Manimēkalai** and **Cīvaka Cintāmani** gives a full account of Tamil concept of womanhood by powerfully and poignantly delineating the character of a chaste wife Kannagi, a brave and dutiful daughter Manimekalai, and an affectionate mother in Vijayai, mother of Jivakan in the three epics respectively.

42 Among these, the last two, **Valayapathi** and **Kuṇṭalakēci** are not extant.

TAMIL (SANGAM) LITERATURE



43 In Tamil speaking regions, the twelve **Alvars** or saint poets who were immersed in the devotion of God, wrote several texts.

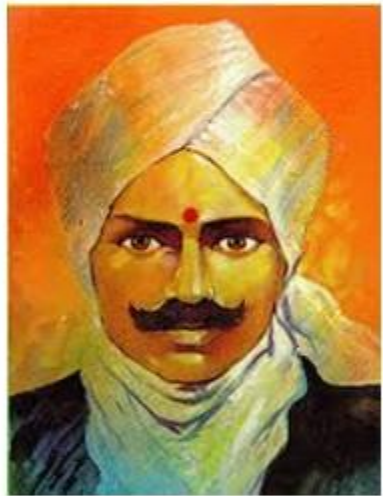
44 One of the Alvar saints was a woman, called **Andal**.

45 This was supposed to be a step **ahead of the misogyny** of that time.

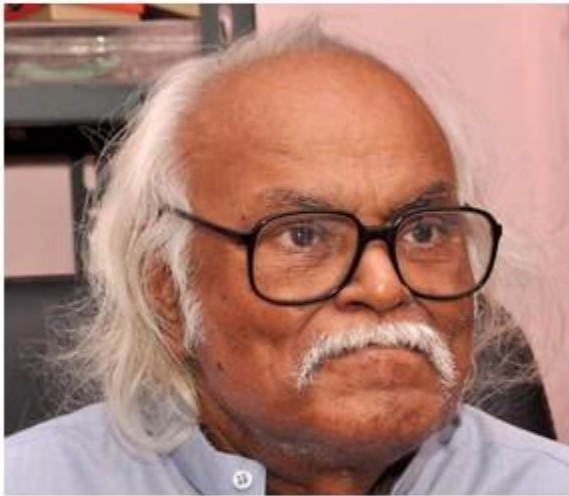
46 Another important Bhakti group was of the **Nayanars** or those who sang the praise of Shaivism.

47 Besides these, in the secular Tamil writing, two major works called **Periya Puranam & Kambaramayanam** were very popular.

TAMIL (SANGAM) LITERATURE



BHARATHI



JAYAKANTHAN

48

In modern period,

- Samuel Vedanayagam Pillai was the first Tamil Novelist,
- Subramanya Bharathi was a renowned litterateur who wrote inspirational and patriotic poems and songs.
- U.V Swaminatha Iyer (poet) worked for revival of interest in Sangam literature.

49

Other prominently Tamil litterateurs of the modern period are

- Akilan (novelist and short story writer; Jnanpith awardee) and
- Jayakanthan (writer and journalist who won Sahitya Akademi, Jnanpith, Padma Bhushan, the Soviet Land Nehru Award, and the Russian government's Order of Friendship)

REGIONAL LITERATURE

MALAYALAM LITERATURE

- 1 Malayalam traces its origin to the 9th Century CE. Earlier forms of Malayalam Literature could be an admixture of Malayalam and Tamil, Malayalam and Sanskrit or pure Malayalam.



Thunchaththu Ramanujan Ezhuthachan

- 2 In the subsequent centuries, besides a popular pattu ("song") literature, the manipravalam poetry also flourished. Manipravalam style consisted of poetry in an admixture of Malayalam and Sanskrit
- 3 Later, poets like Cherusseri introduced poems on devotional themes. There were also other important works, in Arabi Malayalam like Muhyadheen Mala.
- 4 Ezhuthachan, a strong proponent of Bhakti movement, is known as the Father of Malayalam. One of his prominent work is Adhyatma Ramayanam.

- He founded the Kerala Kalamandalam
- Credited with revitalising the traditional Keralite dance form known as Kathakali..

VALLATHOL
NARAYANA MENON



- Disciple of Narayana Guru
- Important person in Temple Entry Movement; empathetic towards the ezhava community.

N.KUMARAN ASAN



TRIUMVIRATE
POETS OF
KERALA

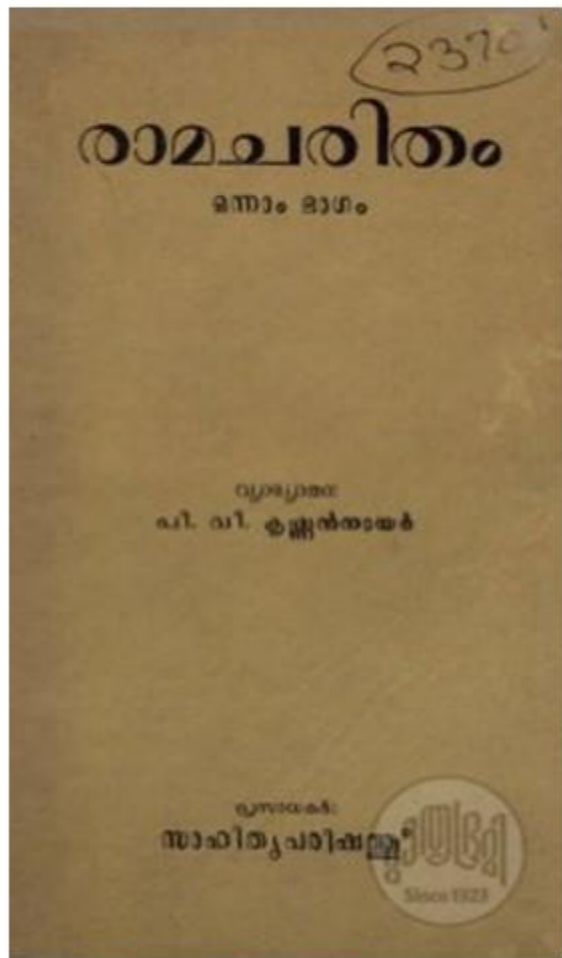
Umakeralam, a mahakavya, & Kerala Sahitya Charithram, a comprehensive history of Malayalam language, are two of his greatest works.

ULLOOR S.PARAMESHWARA
IYER



REGIONAL LITERATURE

MALAYALAM LITERATURE



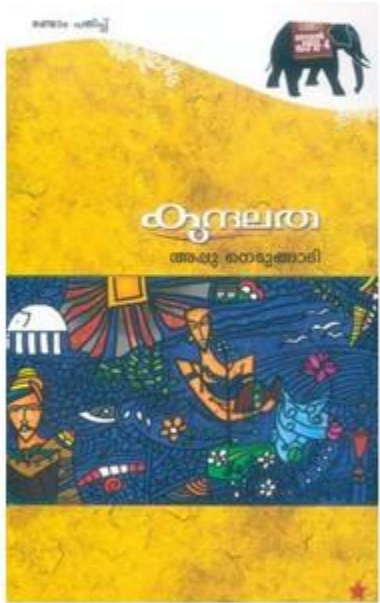
5 Ramacharitam by Cheeramakavi (8th century) is among the oldest, Malayalam Literature.

6 C. Namboothri's Krishnagatha is an important treatise of the medieval period.

7 The tendency of the modern poetry is often towards political radicalism.

REGIONAL LITERATURE

MALAYALAM LITERATURE

**Kundalata****S.K. Pottekkatt****M.T. Vasudevan Nair**

8

Kundalata (1887) by Appu Nedungadi is considered the first Malayalam novel.

9

Important modern Malayali literatures include

- **O. Chandu Menon** (Novel Writer),
- P.Kesava Dev,
- Vaikom Mohammed Basheer (Sahitya Akademi and Padma Shri awardee),
- G. Sankara Kurup (Sahitya Akademi, Jnanpith and Padma Bhushan awardee),
- **S.K. Pottekkatt** (Sahitya Akademi and Jnanpith awardee) and
- **M.T. Vasudevan Nair** (Sahitya Akademi, Jnanpith and Padma Bhushan Awardee)

LITERATURE OF INDIA

MAINS QUESTION

Qn Though not very useful from the point of view of a connected political history of South India, the Sangam literature portrays the social and economic conditions of its time with remarkable vividness. Comment.

Qn “Falsehood takes the place of truth when it results in unblemished common good.” _ Tirukkural

PRACTICE QUESTION

Qn Describe the role of Sanskrit in the development of literature in ancient India.

Qn Why is Tamil literature known as Sangam literature.

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